

God is Breath Training Program - Course 1

Breath, Concentration, and the God Ideal

Lesson 2 Practices and Assignments

(by Murshid Wali Ali, with some updates by Sheikh Muiz)

Dear Friends,

Peace be with you on the path we are taking together. I am happy that we have formed a caravan for the ongoing realization of the wonders to be found in the Breath.

Below are the basic practices that have been assigned for Lesson 2. The first 7 can be done together at a convenient time daily. If you prefer, you can do #4 - #7 at a different time. Practices 8 and 9, are to be done in the course of everyday life in the midst of activity, or taking a slight pause from activity, and the journaling at point or points during the week.

Our purpose is to dig deep into the practice and the teachings. I believe the amount of material we are devoting to practice is quite practical and doable. I haven't overloaded us with study material so that we have time to proceed with proper concentration and not rush through the texts we are studying, but to savor them and reflect on them.

Maintaining a daily rhythm of concentration will be highly beneficial for us all. May we be graced to keep remembering our focus and to feel the beauty at the heart of our process.

Love and Blessings,
Wali Ali, 2013

Some specific daily practices to take on for Lesson 2:

1) Sufi Invocation – 3 times

Begin with recitation of the Sufi Invocation 3 times, followed by inner reflection connecting with the meaning and intention of this prayer.

2) Ya Raqib – 33 times vocally, then several times on the breath (Fikr), then a few more breaths just feeling the essence of it without the mental recitation (Fikr as-Sirr)

After the vocalizations, make the breath more gentle and refined, and carry Ya Raqib in the swing of the breath, several times more, while repeating it mentally and in feeling, in time with the inhalations and exhalations (Fikr).

And then a few more breaths, more gentle, more refined, letting go of the mental repetitions, and calling forth heart-centered attention and interest in what you are focused upon in your awareness. Opening to just feeling the essence of it, as you inhale and exhale, allowing it to penetrate and permeate more deeply (Fikr as-Sirr, the secret of the Fikr),

3) Daily Sitting Meditation – 15 minutes

Stage 1: Allow yourself to breathe naturally. Notice the rhythm of this breath and consciously maintain this rhythm. Gradually allow the breath to become longer and more refined. Become aware of the small natural pause at the top and bottom of the breath.

Stage 2: Place your attention on the magnetism (prana) that is carried by the breath. You are

drawing from the all-pervading life in space. Center your awareness in the heart (middle of the chest) and consciously bring the magnetism into the heart as you inhale and radiate it as you exhale. Your whole physical body becomes charged with life-force.

Stage 3: Call all this feeling forth as love. Using the rhythm that has been established in your breath, stay attentive to this regular swing — long, refined, rhythmical. If the breath begins to stray from this state gently bring it back.

Begin to slowly intone the sound “Allah, Allah” in thought and feeling and let remembrance of the perfect One naturally fill the breath. Constantly flow with the awareness of the joy of the essence of your life in Allah, and be alive to love's longing for completion in Allah.

4) Recite Sura Ikhlas in Arabic 10 times

Let the vibration of the words resonate within as you hold the meanings in mind and heart, like you would with any wazifa, or mantra.

This practice and the following breath contemplation can help in opening and attuning to the ineffable container of Absolute Unity and Oneness that the Name Allah points towards, through a concentration on two of the fundamental Names or Qualities of Allah – al-'Ahad and as-Samad, the One that has no second, and the Eternal Ever-Becoming One; the dot from which the entire universe emerged at the beginning of time, and the eternally expanding circle, or sphere of Oneness whose center is everywhere.

Surah al-Ikhlâs – The Sincerity

*(Surah 112 from the Qu'ran, also referred to as The Unity, or The Oneness of Allah
In answer to the questions "Who is this Allah
that you're teaching us about, what is the nature of this Allah?"
Prophet Muhammad received this Surah)*

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim

*(We begin) in the Name of Allah, Everlasting Mercy, Infinite Compassion.
(OPTION: The Bismillah can be repeated with each recitation, or just the first time.)*

Qul huwa Allahu 'Ahad

Say, Hu is Allah, The One

Allahu us-Samad

Allah, The Eternal, Absolute

Lam yalid, wa lam yulad

Hu never gave birth, and Hu never was born

wa lam yaku llahu kufuwan 'Ahad

And there is none comparable to The One.

5) Breath Contemplation using Ya 'Ahad Ya Samad – 5 minutes

Follow the recitation of Surah Ikhlas with a breathing contemplation practice using Ya 'Ahad and Ya Samad.

When you exhale, mentally and in feeling repeat "Ya Samad", continually dissolving into the Oneness that is unending. Breathing out "Ya Samad" is the same as breathing out "Toward the One" and "becoming melting snow", dissolving the sense of your small self into the eternal, continuous and unending, All-Pervading Oneness.

When you inhale, mentally and in feeling repeat "Ya 'Ahad.". There is nothing outside of the Unity of the One that is al-'Ahad. Experience this Unity as a dot, and with the inhalation of Ya 'Ahad draw the reality of All That Is into a dot and experience integration of self in this dot. You become aware of the One that is the ultimate Unity of Being. Nothing is outside of this One. Nothing can be added to it or subtracted from it.

To be fully conscious as you perform this practice asks you to accept that what you call your own awareness is actually an activity of the Only Being, and is nothing but that Being.

This practice is highly recommended because oscillating back and forth between the dot and the continuation of the infinite and eternal circumference of the expanding circle gives the right psychological framework for progress in meditation. It allows us to ease into the letting go of self, of "dying before death".

The Sufi Invocation uses all these levels of meaning of the One.

6) Separate Nostril Breathing Practice – 10 breaths each side

Begin with the left nostril, in and out for 10 breaths, holding the right nostril closed. Make this a long, refined breath with a natural pause at the top and bottom.

Then with the right nostril, in and out for 10 breaths, holding the left nostril closed.

Then attempt to breathe 10 breaths evenly balanced in both nostrils.

Use these exercises to become more aware of the particular feeling conveyed by these three ways of breathing, and notice them periodically throughout the day.

7) 20 Purification Breaths and Healing Prayer

There are many different forms in which this practice is done. In this class we are placing our attention throughout the breaths, on the 3 avenues of purification mentioned in the prayer Nayaz.

Finish the Healing Breaths with Nayaz, the Healing Prayer, again opening to the 3 powers.

The Purification Breaths:

Each breath is slow, gentle, and refined, inhalations and exhalations the same length. Each of the breathing patterns is repeated 5 times, mentally and in feeling repeating "Ya

Shafee" (O Healer) during the inhalations, and "Ya Kafee" (O Remedy, Sufficient for every need) during the exhalations.

1st pattern: IN the NOSE, and OUT the NOSE.

2nd pattern: IN the NOSE, and OUT the MOUTH.

3rd pattern: IN in the MOUTH, and OUT the NOSE.

4th pattern: IN the MOUTH, and OUT the MOUTH.

The Healing Prayer, Nayaz:

"Beloved Lord, almighty God, through the rays of the Sun, through the waves of the air, through Thy All-Pervading Life in Space, purify and revivify me, and I pray, heal my body, heart, and soul."

To be done at any time:

8) Toward the One Walking Practice – at least once a week

Do the following walking practice in nature if possible when you can.

Breathing "Toward the One" in and out from the heart center. Opening, encouraging, and allowing your heart to feel lovingly drawn by the beauty of the Perfect One, and feeling the inner harmony of your connection with the Source and Goal of all, you radiate the light-ray of your intention along the path of your life.

9) Attention to Breath – Periodically throughout the day

Check in with your breath throughout the day and notice its condition. For example, it could be Jelal, Jemal, Kemal, Urooj, Zaval, refined/coarse, powerful/dull, broad/narrow, etc.

After checking in, consciously confirm the rhythm in your breath or, when needed, establish a rhythm in your breath. Stay with this awareness of the swing of your breath and allow it to gradually become longer and more refined.

Then continue with your activities. Notice any way in which your emotions have been influenced by having done the practice mentioned above.

10) Journaling – At least once a week

Continue to write in your journal at least once a week or more. In addition to noting the condition of your breath at different times, and what you learned from it, also give some attention in your journal to the different things that your breath connects with and what it draws from that connection.